

Crime and Punishment

A 20-Minute Read

Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866) — Episode 8 of the Top 10 Books series

A former student with a theory, an axe, and a fever. This summary gives you the story, the extraordinary man theory, the cat-and-mouse investigation, Sonya's role, and the confession — and why the epilogue still divides readers — in about twenty minutes of reading.

The book in 60 seconds

Crime and Punishment is Dostoevsky's breakthrough novel, published in installments in 1866, written in a panic of debt and deadlines, and still the template for every psychological crime story since. On the surface: a destitute former law student in St. Petersburg murders an old pawnbroker, steals her money — and never spends it. Underneath: a six-hundred-page autopsy of an idea. Raskolnikov has convinced himself that "extraordinary" people may step over the moral law for a great purpose. The novel tests that idea not in a seminar but in a garret, on a stairwell, and in a police station — and the idea fails not because someone refutes it, but because the man who tries to live by it cannot bear what he has done to himself.

Around Raskolnikov orbit the detective Porfiry, who understands him better than evidence could; Sonya, the meek daughter of a drunk, forced into prostitution to feed her family, who becomes his moral anchor; Svidrigailov, the dark mirror of a man who may have lived without conscience and found only emptiness; Luzhin, the respectable villain who harms without breaking a law; and Razumikhin, the loyal friend who is Dostoevsky's quiet counter-argument. No other novel makes guilt so physical, or confession so dramatic.

The story

The garret and the letter. Rodion Romanovich Raskolnikov has dropped out of university for lack of money. He lives in a tiny room under a roof — more cupboard than lodging — owes rent, avoids his landlady, and has eaten almost nothing for days. He has pawned his father's watch to Alyona Ivanovna, an old pawnbroker he despises as a harmful "louse" draining the poor. For over a month he has been circling a plan: kill her, take her money, and use it for good — for his education, his mother, a hundred worthy acts that would, in his arithmetic, outweigh one worthless life.

A letter from his mother breaks his control. His sister Dunya, a governess dismissed after a scandal not of her making, is engaged to Pyotr Luzhin, a prosperous, self-satisfied official. The marriage is partly a rescue operation: Luzhin's position could secure Raskolnikov's future. Raskolnikov reads the sacrifice instantly — Dunya is selling herself for him, as Sonya (whom he has not yet met) sells herself for her family — and resolves to forbid it. He has no money, no standing, nothing but the plan.

The tavern and Marmeladov. In a squalid tavern Raskolnikov meets Semyon Marmeladov, a former official who has drunk his family into ruin. Marmeladov delivers one of literature's great tavern confessions: his wife Katerina, once educated, now consumptive and proud; his daughter Sonya, who has taken a "yellow ticket" — registered as a prostitute — to feed her step-siblings; and himself, who stole the household's last money for drink and begs a strange student's pardon for existing. Raskolnikov walks him home, sees the family's misery firsthand, and leaves his last coins on the windowsill. He is disgusted by his own sentimentality — and cannot stop performing such acts. That doubleness is the man.

The theory rehearsed. Raskolnikov overhears, by chance, a student in a tavern arguing his own thought back to him: the pawnbroker is harmful, her money would do good, kill her and no court of arithmetic would convict. Chance keeps feeding the plan. He learns the pawnbroker will be alone the next evening. He steals an axe, sews a loop into his coat, counts his steps — seven hundred and thirty — like an actor rehearsing a part he half-believes he is only imagining.

The murder. He rings the bell until the old woman, suspicious, opens the door a crack. He gets in, produces a fake pledge, and kills her with the blunt side of the axe. He is rifling her trunk when Lizaveta — the pawnbroker's gentle, exploited half-sister, a woman who embodies every innocence his arithmetic cannot process — walks in. He kills her too. He nearly fails to escape: visitors ring the bell, workmen knock, and he hides behind a door while his heart tries to leave his body. He takes a purse and some pledges, hides them under a stone in a courtyard, and never — this cannot be stressed enough — spends, uses, or even properly examines what he stole.

The fever. What follows is not flight but collapse. Raskolnikov falls into days of delirium, tended by the landlady's servant Nastasya and by Razumikhin, his university friend, who appears like health itself — working, translating, bullying the sick man into eating, falling honestly in love with Dunya. Summoned to the police station over his rent debt, Raskolnikov faints dead away when the conversation turns to the murder. He is drawn back to the crime scene, rings the dead woman's bell, asks about blood — behavior any modern profiler would flag instantly. Dostoevsky, writing decades before Freud, builds a portrait of guilt as physiology: fever, compulsion, self-betrayal.

The detective. Porfiry Petrovich, the investigating magistrate, has read Raskolnikov's published article on crime. In three long interviews — the novel's electric centerpieces — he circles his man with genial, terrifying precision. He discusses the theory of extraordinary men as if over tea. He announces, almost cheerfully, that he knows. He advises confession as a mercy: suffering accepted voluntarily will shorten both the sentence and the torment. He is not Holmes with a magnifying glass; he is a psychologist who understands that this criminal's punishment has already begun and that his only exit is the truth spoken aloud.

Sonya. Marmeladov is run down by a carriage and dies in Sonya's arms, in the family's room, having begged forgiveness. At the funeral dinner, Luzhin — stung because Dunya has broken the engagement after seeing his arrogance — plants a hundred-rouble note in Sonya's pocket

and accuses her of theft, to disgrace her and wound Raskolnikov through her. The fraud collapses when a witness speaks. It is to Sonya that Raskolnikov finally confesses, in her tiny room, after making her read the raising of Lazarus from her New Testament. His explanation dissolves as he speaks it — the money, the theory, Napoleon — until what remains is the novel's most honest sentence in spirit: I wanted to dare, and I killed; I murdered myself, not the old woman. Sonya does not recoil. She gives him her cypress-wood cross, tells him to go to the crossroads, bow, kiss the earth, and say aloud: I am a murderer. "We will go to suffer together," she says, "and together we will bear our cross."

The dark mirror. Svidrigailov, Dunya's former employer, a widower shadowed by rumored crimes, has rented the room next to Sonya's and overheard the confession through the wall. He toys with this knowledge, pursues Dunya one last time — and, when she rejects him at gunpoint yet cannot shoot, lets her go with something like wonder. He gives money to Sonya and to his young fiancée's family, spends a night of dreams about rats and a drowned girl, and at dawn shoots himself in front of a bewildered watchman. He is the theory lived to its end: permission without limit, curdling into boredom and horror.

The confession. Raskolnikov says goodbye to his mother without telling her, receives Dunya's blessing, goes to the crossroads, and kisses the earth while bystanders laugh at the drunk. At the police station he nearly leaves — then sees Sonya's pale face in the yard, turns back, and confesses. The trial is barely shown; Dostoevsky is not interested in verdicts. With mitigating circumstances — the confession, the unused loot, his past kindnesses — the sentence is eight years in Siberia.

The epilogue. In the Siberian prison camp Raskolnikov is at first unrepentant and despised by fellow convicts as godless. He dreams of a plague of microscopic spirits that infect humanity with absolute certainty — each person convinced he alone holds the truth, agreement impossible, civilization devouring itself: his theory become epidemic. Sonya visits, patient as weather. Beside the river, one morning, he weeps and falls at her feet. The novel closes by promising "a new story" — the gradual rebirth of a man — and deliberately does not write it.

Rodion Raskolnikov: the man who tried to step over

Raskolnikov's name derives from *raskol* — schism, split — and he is split in every direction at once. He gives his last money to the Marmeladovs and writes his mother cruel, hectoring letters. He dreams of a beaten horse and wakes weeping, then plans a murder before breakfast. He is proud to the point of mania and tender to the point of self-destruction. Dostoevsky's insight is that this is not hypocrisy but a single condition: a man who has cut himself off from other people experiences his own compassion as an insult, because compassion proves the connection his theory denies.

His arithmetic of the pawnbroker — one worthless life against a hundred saved — is deliberately made almost persuasive, because Dostoevsky wants you to feel the temptation rather than merely observe it. What the novel dismantles is not the calculation's logic but its psychology. Raskolnikov discovers he did not want the money, did not want the future, did not even really want the good deeds. He wanted to know which category he belonged to. The murder was an identity test disguised as social policy — and he failed it, not by being caught, but by discovering he was "a trembling creature" like everyone else, a man for whom other people are not arithmetic.

That is why his suffering is not, at bottom, fear of Siberia. It is the misery of exile from the human community while still living in its middle. He cannot bear his mother's love because it crosses the border he has drawn around himself. He is rude to Razumikhin because friendship is a country he has renounced. "I killed myself, not the old woman" is the novel's thesis spoken by its criminal: the victim of the extraordinary man theory is the extraordinary man.

The story in detail

Why the letter matters. Dostoevsky opens with a financial instrument: a mother's letter full of sacrifice. Dunya's engagement to Luzhin is the legal, respectable version of Sonya's yellow ticket — a woman exchanging herself for her family's survival. Raskolnikov sees the symmetry at once, and it poisons every abstract argument he makes afterward. His theory promises to rescue women like Dunya by stealing from women like the pawnbroker; reality answers that the rescue and the ruin wear the same face. His frantic "I forbid it" to the marriage is the protest of a man with no lawful means of helping anyone — which is precisely the condition his theory claims to cure.

Marmeladov's function. The tavern confession is not local color. Marmeladov introduces the novel's counter-doctrine before the crime has even occurred: a man who has done real harm, who knows it, who drinks anyway, and who believes — in the novel's most startling speech — that the final judgment will pity precisely those who could not help themselves. Where Raskolnikov calculates desert, Marmeladov hopes for mercy. The whole novel is a contest between those two sentences. It is also Marmeladov who gives Raskolnikov the Marmeladov family, and therefore Sonya: the crime's author meets the tragedy's victims before he has committed anything, and gives them his last coins. Dostoevsky loads the dice so that no reader can treat the later confession as a stranger's kindness. It is restitution inside one small world.

Porfiry's method. The three interviews deserve attention as craft. Porfiry never accuses directly. He praises the article, asks the author to explain his categories, mentions that an innocent man has confessed to the murder (the painter Mikolka, a religious dissenter who wants to suffer — a false double who confesses to a crime he did not commit, mirroring Raskolnikov who cannot confess to one he did). Porfiry's climactic visit to Raskolnikov's

garret is a masterpiece of controlled menace: he lays out the case, admits the evidence is thin, and recommends voluntary confession as arithmetic of a different kind — less suffering, shorter term. He leaves by promising to keep his word. The detective as confessor: Dostoevsky invents psychological policing because his subject is not detection but surrender.

The funeral dinner. Katerina Marmeladova, dying and desperate for status, spends the family's relief money on a funeral dinner for lodgers who despise her. The scene is unbearable social comedy curdling into tragedy: the landlady's insults, Katerina's grandeur, Luzhin's planted banknote, Sonya's humiliation, the room's turn when the truth surfaces. Dostoevsky sets his moral climax not in a church but in a rented room with cheap wine, because in this novel grace keeps arriving in undignified places. Luzhin's exposure matters beyond plot: the respectable man who harms within the law is unmasked in public, while the murderer who harms outside it will be redeemed in public too — at a crossroads, before a crowd.

Svidrigailov's night. No section divides readers like Svidrigailov's last day. He is generous — settling money on Sonya, on his fiancée, on the Marmeladov orphans — and damned, dreaming of a five-year-old girl's corrupted face. He tells Raskolnikov they are "berries from the same field," and the horror is that Raskolnikov almost believes him. The difference is not their theories but their guilt: one man suffers his, the other has outlived his capacity to suffer, and finds that what remains is not freedom but a flooded hotel room and hallucinated mice. His suicide at dawn, performed with an almost comic formality — "I'm going to America," he tells the watchman — is the extraordinary man's true destination in Dostoevsky's map.

The crossroads. Sonya's instruction is liturgical, and Raskolnikov obeys it badly: he kneels, kisses the "defiled earth," and is laughed at as a drunk. Dostoevsky refuses him a dignified conversion scene. Then, at the station, the first attempt fails — he walks out — and it is the sight of Sonya, who has followed him silently, that turns him back. The confession is thus not a triumph of will but a response to being accompanied. Eight years, Siberia, and Sonya's visits follow, but the novel's real sentence is pronounced earlier, by Sonya herself: we will suffer together. Together is the verdict.

The ideas that made it famous

1. The extraordinary man theory. In his article, Raskolnikov divides humanity into the ordinary, who reproduce and obey, and the extraordinary — Lycurgus, Mohammed, Napoleon — who move the world and therefore stand, in conscience, beyond its rules. A Newton whose discovery required deaths could, on this account, authorize himself. Dostoevsky builds the theory carefully because it is not stupid: it is the distilled logic of an age intoxicated by utility and great men. The novel's refutation is empirical. The theory predicts a Napoleon; it produces a young man who cannot spend stolen money, cannot look at his mother, and cannot stay out of a police station. A doctrine of human nature that fails its first experiment is not refuted by argument — it is refuted by Raskolnikov.

2. Rational egoism and its doubles. The radicals of the 1860s preached "rational egoism" — enlightened self-interest as social glue. Dostoevsky gives the doctrine three bodies: Raskolnikov's bloody version, Luzhin's legal version (he articulates it himself, praising the man who loves himself first as the engine of progress), and Lebezyatnikov's comic version, a well-meaning progressive parroting the slogans. Against all three stands what critics call the novel's ethic of active love: Razumikhin working, Sonya enduring, Dunya refusing. None of them has a theory. That is their theory.

3. Guilt as knowledge. Long before psychoanalysis, Dostoevsky asserts that the mind knows what the intellect denies. Raskolnikov's reason maintains his innocence of any moral error; his body files daily dissenting reports — fever, fainting, compulsive return, dreams of the beaten horse and of the old woman laughing at him. The novel proposes that conscience is not a rulebook but a mode of perception: to be cut off from others is to be cut off from reality itself, which is why Raskolnikov's world narrows to one room, one stairwell, one recurring bell.

4. Confession vs. detection. The whodunit question is answered in Part 1. The novel's suspense is entirely whether a man can say what he did. Dostoevsky thereby relocates the crime story's center of gravity from the police to the soul — an innovation so complete that we now take it for granted. Porfiry knows; Sonya knows; Svidrigailov knows. The only person who cannot yet afford to know is the murderer, and the plot is the price coming due.

5. Suffering — accepted, refused, and faked. The novel distinguishes three sufferings. Mikolka, the false confessor, seeks suffering as a religious duty, unearned and almost theatrical. Svidrigailov refuses suffering and finds the void. Raskolnikov is led — by Sonya — to accept suffering as the specific shape of his return to others: not pain for its own sake, but the cost of re-entering a shared world. Dostoevsky is often caricatured as glorifying pain; the text is more precise. What redeems is not pain but the end of isolation, for which pain is sometimes the toll.

6. The plague dream. In the epilogue Raskolnikov dreams of trichinae — microscopic spirits of reason — infecting mankind, so that every person becomes certain he alone possesses the truth and society dissolves into warring certainties. Written in 1866, it reads now like a prophecy of ideological pandemics. It is also the theory's final form: a world of extraordinary men, each self-authorized, is not a world of Napoleons but of mutual incomprehension. Dostoevsky puts his rebuttal in a dream because his character still cannot think it awake.

Guilt: the novel's true subject

Strip away the detective machinery and *Crime and Punishment* is a study of how a conscience metabolizes what the intellect has approved.

Guilt begins before the crime. Raskolnikov's misery — the hunger, the avoidance, the cruel letters home — precedes the murder. Dostoevsky's suggestion is unsettling: the theory itself is

already the sickness, and the axe is a symptom mistaken for a cure. He does not kill and therefore fall ill; he is ill, therefore he kills, therefore he falls further ill. The novel's causality is medical before it is legal.

Guilt speaks the body. Fever charts the plot. He commits the murder in a state he later cannot fully remember, conducts his most lucid conversations (with Porfiry, with Sonya) at the edge of delirium, and confesses as the fever finally breaks. Modern readers reach for trauma language; Dostoevsky reached for temperature, and the accuracy startles clinicians to this day. The unconscious, in this novel, does not send symbols. It sends symptoms — and a young man ringing a dead woman's doorbell.

Guilt isolates, and isolation is the punishment. No one sentences Raskolnikov to his real penalty. He imposes it at the moment of the act: he cannot touch his mother's money, accept Razumikhin's help, or remain in a room with Dunya's gratitude. Siberia merely formalizes an exile already in force. This is why Sonya's "together" is the novel's operative word — the antidote is not punishment but accompaniment, and the prison camp, paradoxically, is the first place he is no longer alone.

Guilt, refused, becomes Svidrigailov. The counter-case completes the argument. A man may outrun conscience — Dostoevsky grants the possibility — but what he outruns it into is not Napoleonic calm. It is dreams he cannot bear and a pistol at dawn. Between Raskolnikov's fever and Svidrigailov's boredom, the novel leaves no third country.

And guilt, accepted, becomes the epilogue's quiet. Whatever its flaws, the Siberian ending insists on one proposition: a man is not the worst thing he has argued himself into. The convicts who shunned the "godless" student come, in time, to love Sonya and tolerate him; his pride loosens not under argument but under routine kindness. Dostoevsky calls the unwritten sequel "the story of the gradual renewal of a man." He means renewal as a practice, not an event.

The women who refuse to be arithmetic

Dunya is the novel's clearest intelligence. A governess dismissed after refusing her employer's advances and absorbing the scandal, she weighs Luzhin clear-eyed — she knows what he is; she is buying her brother's life with her own — and breaks the engagement the moment his contempt for her family becomes undeniable. Facing Svidrigailov with his own revolver, she throws the weapon away because she cannot kill, and that inability accomplishes what a shot could not: it shames him into letting her go. Dostoevsky gives her the novel's most effective moral action and lets it be a refusal.

Sonya has been sentimentalized for a century and a half, and the text resists it. She is not pure in the sense of untouched; she is faithful in the sense of undivided. She cannot follow Raskolnikov's theory — she keeps answering argument with person: "What have you done to yourself?" Her reading of Lazarus is not a sermon but a self-disclosure: she reads her own

story, the dead called back by name. When she promises to follow him to Siberia, the novel is not rewarding female self-sacrifice in the abstract; it is showing the only force that has ever moved its hero — being accompanied without being excused.

Katerina Ivanovna, Marmeladov's wife, dies as she lived, demanding recognition from a world that owes her children bread. Her pride is grotesque and entirely intelligible: gentility is the last property of the dispossessed. Her deathbed refusal of a priest — she will manage without ceremonies — is Dostoevsky's respect for a dignity that never once behaved well.

Lizaveta, the murdered innocent, is the theory's standing refutation even in death: gentle, exploited, friend to Sonya, sharer of a cross exchanged between them — the cypress cross Raskolnikov eventually wears to his confession is Lizaveta's, passed through Sonya's hands. The novel's holiest object belongs to its most helpless victim. That is not sentimentality. That is the argument, completed in a prop.

The city: Petersburg as accomplice

Dostoevsky's Petersburg is not a backdrop but a pressure system. Summer heat, the stink of canals, taverns without air, stairwells smelling of oil and cats, rooms like coffins and cupboards — the physical world keeps making Raskolnikov's argument for him: in such a city, what is one louse more or less? The Haymarket, where prostitutes and peasants and drunks circulate, is the novel's true public square; both the crime's planning and its confession happen in its orbit. Bridges recur as thresholds — over the canal where he considers drowning the evidence and himself, before the panorama of the Neva that fills him with terror at his own exile from beauty.

Critics have long noted the novel's yellow: yellow wallpaper in the pawnbroker's flat, the yellow ticket, yellow faces, the yellowish water he cannot drink. Whether Dostoevsky planned the color-scheme or critics invented it, the effect is jaundice — a world seen through a sick man's eyes, or a sick world accurately seen. The novel never decides, and the indecision is the realism.

Dostoevsky's life inside the book

Dostoevsky knew the inside of a cell. Arrested in 1849 for reading banned literature aloud, he stood before a firing squad in a mock execution before his sentence was commuted to Siberian hard labor — the same geography as his hero's ending, experienced in the same order: sentence first, Siberia second. When Raskolnikov's convicts shun him, a man who lived among convicts and wrote a book about them is testifying.

He knew the pawnbroker's arithmetic from the inside of debt. Ruined by his brother's journal debts and his own roulette compulsion, he wrote *Crime and Punishment* while under a

catastrophic contract: fail to deliver another novel by November 1866 and a publisher would own his future work outright. He dictated *The Gambler* in twenty-six days to Anna Snitkina, a twenty-year-old stenographer, while installments of *Crime and Punishment* were appearing — then proposed to her. The novel's fever, its refusal to pause, its sense that every chapter is written against a clock: the biography is in the syntax.

He also knew he was arguing with the young. The radical journals of the 1860s, Chernyshevsky's rational egoists, the first nihilist celebrities — Raskolnikov is Dostoevsky's fear of what his own generation's ideas would do in a gifted, starving student's head. Svidrigailov is the same fear aged twenty years. The novel is sometimes read as a conservative tract; it is better read as a dispatch from a man who had been the young radical, had stood before the rifles for it, and had earned the right to ask what the ideas cost when somebody finally acts on them.

How to approach reading it

Choose your translation. David McDuff's version is widely praised for keeping Dostoevsky's jagged urgency; Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky's is the other standard recommendation, more literal and deliberately unpolished. The old Constance Garnett translation reads smoothly but sands down the fever. This is a novel where the roughness is the meaning.

Let Part 1 be slow. The murder arrives early and everything after is aftershock. Readers who sprint to the crime as a climax feel cheated by six hundred pages of "aftermath"; readers who understand that the aftermath is the novel find the most gripping book of the century. Watch the rehearsals — the counted steps, the sewn loop — as a man trying to become a character in his own theory.

Track the doubles. Every major male character is a possible Raskolnikov: Razumikhin (work and loyalty), Luzhin (the theory in a suit, harming legally), Svidrigailov (the theory without guilt), Porfiry (the theory's analyst, who has read the article and waits), even Mikolka, who confesses to the murder he did not commit while the murderer cannot confess to his. Reading the novel as a hall of mirrors around one conscience turns its length into architecture.

Do not skip the tavern. Marmeladov's first speech feels like a detour. It is the thesis statement of the other side, delivered before the crime, by a man who has everything to be ashamed of and hopes anyway. When Sonya later tells Raskolnikov what to do at the crossroads, you will realize you have heard the instructions before — in a drunk's voice, over cheap vodka, in the novel's first hour.

Expect the epilogue argument and join it. A century and a half of readers have fought over those final pages. Read them as what they are — a beginning Dostoevsky declines to narrate — and decide for yourself whether the renewal is earned on credit by everything before it.

Memorable lines

Short, attributed, and worth carrying:

- *"Pain and suffering are always inevitable for a large intelligence and a deep heart."* — Raskolnikov
- *"I did not bow down to you, I bowed down to all the suffering of humanity."* — Raskolnikov, to Sonya
- *"We are cursed together, and together we will go."* — Sonya, to Raskolnikov
- *"To go wrong in one's own way is better than to go right in someone else's."* — Razumikhin
- *"If he has a conscience he will suffer for his mistake. That will be punishment — as well as the prison."* — Porfiry
- *"It's a hundred years since anyone has seen the world turned upside down like this"* in spirit — the novel's taverns and stairwells keep announcing that the old order's language no longer fits anyone's life.

Note: exact wording varies by translation — McDuff, Pevear and Volokhonsky, and Garnett each render these differently. The sense, not the syllable, is Dostoevsky's.

Fair criticisms

The coincidences strain. Raskolnikov overhears his own theory debated in a tavern, overhears the pawnbroker's schedule in another, and finds Svidrigailov listening through Sonya's wall. Nineteenth-century serial fiction ran on such fuel, but modern readers feel the machinery creak. The defense — that a feverish man experiences a contingent world as a conspiracy aimed at him — is real, and only partly sufficient.

The epilogue is hurried. After six hundred pages of the most patient psychology in literature, the conversion arrives in summary. Readers who find it unearned include many who love the novel. Dostoevsky's counter-claim, implicit in the text, is that renewal cannot be dramatized the way guilt can, because it has no plot — only duration. You must decide whether that is wisdom or evasion.

Sonya asks much of modern readers. A heroine whose virtue is endurance, who follows her murderer to Siberia, can read today as an idealization of female self-erasure. The fairest response is double: the pattern is real and worth naming, and Dostoevsky also gives Dunya the novel's most decisive action and Sonya its most authoritative voice — no one else in the book is obeyed the way she is obeyed.

The melodrama is unembarrassed. People swoon, shriek, tear their hair, and confess in taverns at operatic length. Calibrate: this is a novel in which feelings are structural forces, not

decorations, and the fever is the style. Readers who adjust find the psychology underneath the theatrics brutally exact.

Why it's on the list

Because it invents the modern psychological crime novel while refuting the idea that tempts its hero — and ours. Every era produces its version of the extraordinary man: the founder who may break rules, the genius exempt from ordinary accounting, the calculator for whom other people are sums. Dostoevsky, in 1866, already knew the type from the inside, and he followed one such young man from a garret to a crossroads without blinking.

Within this series it is also the dark twin of Episode 2. *The Brothers Karamazov* asks what happens when "everything is permitted" is spoken at a family table; *Crime and Punishment* asks what happens when it is spoken in an empty room, to oneself. Nietzsche — Episodes 1 and 6 — would soon announce that God is dead and summon the Overman. Dostoevsky had already written the Overman's police file, and his prognosis: not a superman but a sick student, ringing a dead woman's bell, waiting for someone to tell him to kiss the earth. The two visions still contend for the modern world. This novel is half the argument, and it is the half with a body count.

What to read next

- **Dostoevsky, the precursor:** *Notes from Underground* — the spiteful underground man is Raskolnikov before the axe; a single evening's reading and the source code of modern alienation.
- **Dostoevsky, the expansion:** *Demons* — the extraordinary man theory enters politics and becomes terrorism; the most frightening of his novels and the most prophetic.
- **Dostoevsky, the inversion:** *The Idiot* — Prince Myshkin, a man attempting to live by pure compassion among Raskolnikovs; Dostoevsky called him his attempt at a wholly beautiful man.
- **The descendants:** Patricia Highsmith's Ripley novels (guilt refused, charm intact), and any modern crime story that cares why more than who — all of them are paying this book rent.